Jews of Arab descent, and then Russians in the 1990s—who would go on to form Likud's base. They faced endemic discrimination from the country's Labor-dominated elite, but Likud, under the savvy leadership of Menachem Begin, gave them a political home.

Oddly, given Netanyahu's mid-30s approval rating, Likud presented the prime minister as almost the sole face of its campaign. He usually appeared alone on advertisements, alongside the slogan "only Likud, only Netanyahu." It was an attitude that seemed destined to hurt the party. On a visit to Sderot five days before the election, many lifelong Likudniks told me they planned to vote for Kulanu, led by a popular ex-Likud minister, Moshe Kahlon, or simply not vote at all. "I've always voted for Likud. My parents voted for Likud," said one man. "But he hasn't done anything for us. Six years, and it's all words. He says he's a strong leader, but he's just verbally strong."

A week before the election, Netanyahu toured Mahane Yehuda, a teeming market in Jerusalem that traditionally votes Likud. Visits to the *shuk* are a rite of passage in Israeli politics, akin to eating corn dogs at the Iowa state fair. But Netanyahu didn't take the media along. He cited security concerns. There were none. The real worry was political; vendors in the *shuk* said they were also leaning towards Kulanu. Netanyahu had to cancel a rally in Ashdod, another Likud stronghold, when party activists could not find enough bodies to fill the event hall.

For all the fatigue and confusion, however, right-wing voters were clear about one thing: they were not crossing the divide to back the Zionist Camp. The party plateaued in most surveys at around twenty-four seats, just one-fifth of the Knesset. Herzog cut a bland and professorial figure, despite hiring a coach to work on his reedy voice. The *Ha'aretz* columnist Ari Shavit wrote a fawning profile that—even so—described him as a "bar mitzvah boy". His running mate, former justice minister Tzipi Livni, is one of Israel's least popular politicians. Many judge her as a self-interested carpetbagger, and by 2015 she was on her fourth political home. Even the unpopular President Obama had a higher favorable rating among Israelis than she did.

With eleven parties poised to enter the next Knesset, the campaign became intensely personal. At one point or another, it seems, every party leader attacked the other ten. Candidates accused each other of racism, corruption, terrorism. The average voter was often hard-pressed to explain